



Mother-of-pearl coyote

△ **Quetzalcoatl**, the Mesoamerican god of wind and learning

This fascinating and striking object is a lid for an effigy jar (a vessel styled as human or animal) from the Toltec civilization of Mesoamerica (c.900–c.1150 CE).

According to one theory, the lid portrays the god Quetzalcoatl with human features, but it is more widely thought to represent a Toltec warrior's helmet, which imitated a coyote's head and had an opening for the warrior's face between its jaws.

The lid displays intricate craftsmanship: it is modelled in clay and inlaid with carved mother-of-pearl and bone. The helmet it depicts is that of the Coyote order, one of the military classes of the Toltec, which included the Eagle and Jaguar, among others. Such a helmet indicated a degree of military rank, while also signifying a state of existence between the material world and the animal spirit world. Warriors also dressed in imitation of the animal's body.

The artefact was found in Tula (in modern-day Mexico), once the capital city of the Toltec Empire. The Toltec, who predated the Aztec, were a warlike people



Portrait of a Native American man wearing a coyote head dress – the animal remained a powerful symbol for many cultures

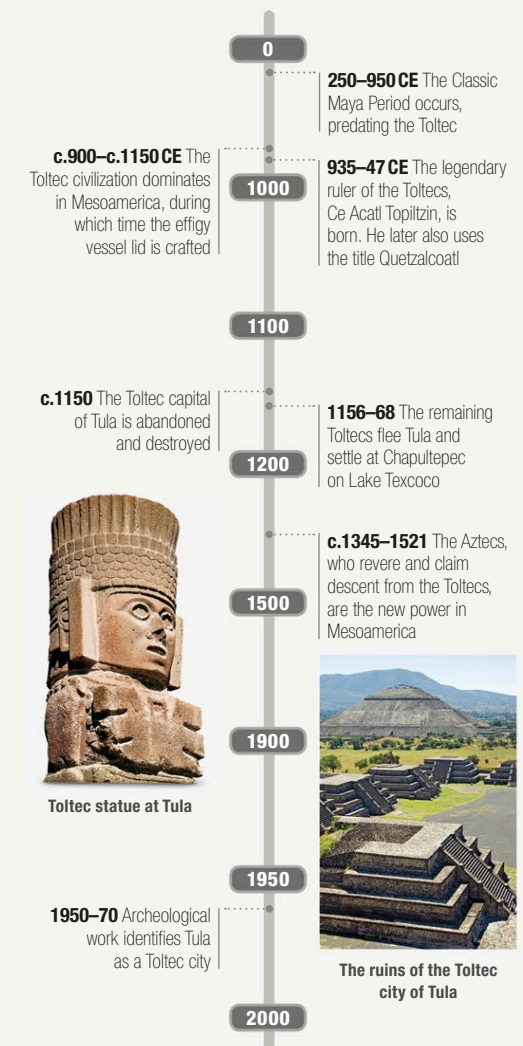
who dominated the region through military force. Religion played an important role in their lives, and human sacrifice to appease the gods was a key component of worship. Evidence of this at Tula includes a *tzompantli*, a skull rack for displaying the heads of sacrificial victims. In addition, three *chacmool* statues were found – reclining warrior figures clutching bowls intended to receive human hearts and other sacrificial offerings for the gods.



Chacmool statue from the Toltec era. The Toltec religion included sacrifice, and these statues were made to hold human organs for the gods

Key dates

250 CE–1970



The Toltecs of tradition were chiefly remarkable for their intense love of art

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